

CHAPTER 43 — Inside / Outside

Saturday morning, Jackie said no three times before breakfast.

No, she did not want the door left open.

No, she did not want the officer from yesterday sitting in.

No, she did not want anyone contacting her siblings yet.

The solicitor wrote all three down.

Jackie noticed.

The room was in a council building that looked exactly like every council building Jackie had ever imagined.

Grey carpet.

Plastic chairs.

A clock that made too much noise.

A box of tissues positioned where someone had decided frightened people would see it.

The solicitor was called Nisha Patel.

Jackie had checked.

Twice.

Practising certificate.

Firm website.

Office number called independently from a council phone.

Nisha had tolerated the whole process with suspicious good humour.

"You can stop checking me now."

"No."

"Fair."

Jackie liked her.

That was dangerous.

She did not let it change anything.

Across the table sat Claire, the safeguarding officer who had collected most of Jackie's first account the night before.

No uniform.

No performance.

She had already explained that Jackie was not under arrest, did not have to give a complete account today and could stop whenever she wanted.

Jackie had tested that.

"If I stop, do you send me back?"

"No."

"Who decides?"

"Not Cain. Not the people who moved you yesterday."

"That wasn't my question."

Claire nodded.

"Children's services. With legal oversight if it becomes necessary."

"Can they change their minds?"

"Yes."

Jackie looked at Nisha.

"True?"

"Yes."

Good.

Promises had become suspicious. Limits were better. Claire opened her notebook. "Where do you want to start?" "With what I'm not telling

you.”

Claire waited. “My brother and sisters.”

“Okay.”

“I don’t know where they are.”

“Okay.”

“If you find them, you don’t automatically tell me their addresses.”

Claire’s eyebrows moved. “Why?”

“Because people got to me through them.”

Nisha wrote. “And don’t put all four of us in one file every idiot can open.”

“We can require restricted handling where the risk supports it.”

“Better.”

Jackie pointed at Nisha’s pad. “Write exactly that.”

“I am.”

Claire almost smiled. Jackie caught her.

“Don’t.”

“Sorry.”

“No, you’re not.”

“No.”

Good.

* * *

At nine eleven, Zoe was still asleep.

Elias knew because she had not complained about the curtains.

Their room sat above a pub in a village where apparently nobody believed Saturday morning should begin before ten.

He sat by the window with coffee.

The receiver remained silent.

That was good.

At nine sixteen, Zoe moved under the duvet.

At nine eighteen:

“What time?”

“Nine eighteen.”

One eye opened.

“Why are you awake?”

“Morning.”

“Suspicious.”

“Normal.”

She sat up.

Her hair pointed in several directions at once.

“Anything?”

“No.”

The answer disappointed her.

Also relieved her.

Jackie was somewhere else now.

Inside a process Zoe did not control.

For once, that was not automatically a bad thing.

Zoe reached for the notebook.

Stopped.

Breakfast first.

Elias said nothing.

She looked at him.

“That counts as praise, doesn’t it?”

“No.”

“Liar.”

* * *

At ten, Jackie began with the houses.

Not addresses.

She did not know most of those anyway.

She described what she remembered.

The first place after Helen and Brian’s house had two men she recognised from earlier surveillance.

The second looked more complicated.

Staff rota.

Medication cabinet.

Fire-door checks.

The kind of things a real residential unit might have.

One woman there had asked Jackie if she wanted to speak to her social worker.

Jackie had said yes.

Another adult immediately said her contact was restricted.

Claire stopped writing.

“Do you know the first worker’s name?”

“First name.”

“Do you want to give it?”

Jackie thought.

The woman might have been part of it.

She might also have been an ordinary worker who believed the restriction was legitimate.

"Yes. But mark her as maybe normal."

Claire looked at Nisha.

"Her wording," Nisha said.

Claire wrote:

Possibly legitimate staff member. No evidence of knowing unlawful restriction.

Jackie leaned across.

Read it.

"Fine."

The third property had been a flat above offices.

The fourth was the suburban house. Some adults appeared at more than one place. Same legal woman twice. Same driver three times. Cain twice. Another man Jackie never identified appeared at three. Claire asked: "What made you think Cain was in charge?"

Jackie frowned. "He wasn't always."

"What do you mean?"

"People argued with him."

"Who?"

"The legal woman. Another man once on speaker."

"About?"

"Records. Westmere. Moving me."

"Did they take instructions from Cain?"

"Sometimes."

"Always?"

"No."

Claire stopped. Jackie noticed. Adults liked simple shapes.

Boss.

Employee.

Victim.

Witness.

One man at the top.

Everyone else beneath him.

"There isn't one person," Jackie said.

Claire looked up.

"They have different bits."

"What bits?"

"Where people are. Paperwork. Houses. Cars. Who signs something. Who checks it. Who you call when something goes wrong."

"And Cain?"

Jackie thought.

"Cain is scary because he can move people."

Claire waited.

"That doesn't mean he owns everything."

Nisha looked at Claire.

Claire wrote it down.

Jackie approved.

* * *

At ten thirty-eight, Cain sent Mac one message.

MEET. 12:00. SAME OFFICE.

Mac stared at the screen.

Margaret Shaw sat opposite him in a hotel lounge twenty miles from his house.

She had refused every location connected to him.

"He knows," Mac said.

"Probably."

"About Jackie."

"Yes."

"He'll know somebody opened the route."

"Yes."

Mac put the phone down.

"What do I tell him?"

"The truth."

He laughed.

Margaret did not.

"Which truth?"

"That you referred a child into current safeguarding after discovering her transfer authority was disputed."

"That sounds cleaner than it was."

"It was still true."

Mac looked at Cain's message.

"If I admit it, I'm finished with him."

Margaret tilted her head.

"You think you aren't already?"

Mac said nothing.

"Are you going?"

He looked at the time. Then at the message. "No."

Margaret nodded once. No congratulations. No declaration. Mac turned the phone face down. "If I don't go, he knows."

"Yes."

"If I do go?"

"He may decide you're the next problem to contain."

"Physically?"

"Possibly."

"Useful."

Margaret leaned forward. "You are still talking as though Cain is the only problem."

"He's a large one."

"Yes."

She held his gaze. "He is not the only record of what you did."

Mac looked away. That was the part he could not escape by changing sides.

Helen remembered. Brian remembered. The archive remained. Zoe remained. Margaret said: "If you help now, it does not rewrite before." "I know." This time, he did.

* * *

At eleven, Claire asked about Zoe. She had waited. Jackie appreciated that. "Do you know where she is?" "No." "Who she is with?" Jackie looked at Nisha. Nisha said: "Answer what you know and what you

choose." "Elias." "Full name?" "I know it." "Do you want to give it?"
"No."

Claire nodded. "Why?" "I don't know you well enough." "Fair." "And adults keep saying urgent when they really mean give me control." Claire accepted that too. Jackie liked her slightly more. Still dangerous. Claire closed the notebook. "We are concerned Zoe may be at risk."
"She is."

"Could you contact her?" "Not directly." "Could somebody relay something?" Jackie thought of Priya. Voss. The routes they were already using. "Yes." Claire said: "Would you ask her one question?" "What?" "Would she speak to an independent solicitor she chooses herself?" Jackie stared.

"Not police?"

"No."

"Not you?"

"No."

"Does she have to tell the solicitor where she is?"

"Not just to make initial contact."

"Then why?"

Claire considered before answering.

"Because several adults and organisations could now claim they are protecting Zoe."

Jackie waited.

"We need a way to hear what Zoe wants."

Jackie smiled.

"There."

Claire frowned.

"What?"

“That’s the right question.”

* * *

The request reached Zoe before noon.

Priya kept it simple.

Current safeguarding wanted Zoe offered independent legal advice.

The solicitor would be Zoe’s choice.

Initial contact did not require her location.

The purpose was to establish that she was alive, could speak for herself and had wishes of her own.

Zoe read it twice.

Elias waited.

“What do you think?”

“Could be useful.”

“Risk?”

“Voice. Metadata. Whatever legal duties the solicitor has.”

“Yes.”

“Benefit?”

“Someone independent knows I’m alive.”

“Yes.”

“Knows you aren’t holding me.”

“Yes.”

“Knows I don’t want everyone getting my location.”

“Potentially.”

Zoe looked down at the message.

One more record.

Not generated by Mac.

Not Westmere.

Not Cain.

Not Voss.

Not Elias.

Not Helen or Brian.

Hers.

"Can I choose Priya?"

"Probably not ideal."

"Voss."

"Yes."

"Right."

Priya supplied independent names.

Zoe checked them.

One had connections she did not want to untangle.

Another was unsuitable for the remote setup they needed.

The third was Ruth Ellison.

Children law.

Independent practice.

No obvious connection to Westmere, Meridian, North Vale, Voss, Mac or anybody else already inside the story.

Zoe checked the public details.

Priya checked separately.

Elias called the published office number.

Zoe looked at him.

"This is ridiculous."

"Useful."

"Purple penguin for solicitors."

"No."

She smiled.

Then looked at Ruth Ellison's name again. "I'll speak to her." No permission asked. None given.

* * *

At noon, Cain waited in the office. Mac did not come. At twelve oh five, Cain called. No answer. At twelve ten, he called restricted legal.

"Where is Mac?"

"I don't know."

"Find him."

"We are not field operations."

"You know what I mean."

Silence. Cain heard it. He changed direction. "Did you know Jackie had been handed into current safeguarding?"

"Yes."

"Before me?"

"Yes."

"Who initiated it?"

Pause.

Cain understood enough.

"Patch me to Margaret."

"No."

He almost missed the word.

"What?"

"No."

Cain stood.

"Since when do you refuse me?"

"Since every conversation with you started becoming something I may have to explain later."

"Careful."

"No."

The voice on the other end was steady now.

"That is exactly the problem."

The line ended.

Cain stared at the phone.

No argument.

No announcement of betrayal.

Someone had simply stopped obeying him.

* * *

At twelve twenty-eight, Helen opened the letter.

Recorded delivery.

Paper.

Brian stood behind her.

It came from the safeguarding review opened after North Vale and Westmere compared historic records.

It did not accuse them.

It asked questions.

Historic placement.

Sponsor contact.

Documents they had retained.

Whether anyone had instructed them not to speak directly to statutory authorities.

Whether they believed Zoe was currently missing or at risk.

Helen read the final question twice.

Brian said:

“Call Mac.”

Helen looked at him.

He regretted it immediately.

“No.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

“Yes.”

She folded the letter.

Brian sat at the kitchen table.

“What do we say?”

“I don’t know.”

“We need a lawyer.”

“Yes.”

“Mac’s—”

He stopped himself. Helen stared. “Stupid,” Brian said.

"Yes."

He almost smiled. Didn't. Helen opened the letter again. "They know enough to ask."

"Not everything."

"No."

Brian rubbed his hands together. "We could say we thought it was private adoption."

Helen looked at him. "Did we?"

Silence. "We could say Mac handled the legal side."

"He did."

"Did we think it was legal?"

Brian stared at the table. Helen waited.

"No."

The word sat between them. Five years late.

Still true.

Helen nodded.

"Then we start there."

* * *

At two, Jackie asked to stop.

Claire looked concerned.

"Are you okay?"

"I'm hungry."

"Oh."

"And I'm not eating sandwiches from that fridge."

"Why?"

"Yesterday's cheese was wet."

Nisha looked appalled.

"That is a safeguarding issue."

Jackie laughed.

Claire did too.

The room became something else for a few minutes.

Not safe forever.

Just ordinary enough.

Jackie bought chips from the café downstairs.

Nisha sat opposite her. "You know you don't have to solve Zoe's case."

Jackie stabbed a chip. "I know."

"Do you?"

Jackie looked up. Everyone had started doing that. Annoying. "I have information."

"Yes."

"I should use it."

"Yes."

"That doesn't mean I'm solving everything."

"No."

Jackie frowned at the chips. "I spent my whole life doing things for other people."

Nisha waited. "My brother. My sisters. Dad. Zoe."

"Okay."

"I don't know how not to."

Nisha did not rush to fix that. "You don't have to learn today."

Jackie looked at her.

That answer irritated her less than most.

Good.

* * *

At two forty, Mac sent Margaret one document.

His original sponsor-introduction agreement.

His name.

His signature.

AC019.

The clause that allowed private placement-support referrals through restricted legal channels.

No children's names.

No recipient addresses.

Nothing about Jackie.

Nothing about where Zoe was now.

Just Mac.

His part.

Margaret called him.

"Why this?"

"If I disappear, somebody should have the part with my name on it."

"Original?"

"Copy."

"Where is the original?"

"No."

She almost laughed.

"Still you."

"Yes."

"Do not expect this to buy you anything."

"I don't."

"Good."

Mac looked through the windscreen of the car he had parked at a motorway services.

He had not gone home.

Had not gone to Cain.

Had not decided where he would sleep.

"Send it somewhere independent."

"I will."

"Not legacy."

"Obviously."

"And Zoe?"

"When her own representative considers it relevant and safe."

Mac gave a humourless smile.

"She'll hate that."

"Probably."

"Good."

Margaret ended the call.

* * *

At three fifteen, Cain tried to find Jackie.

Not through the people who had moved her.

Through the systems behind them.

There was now a safeguarding record.

Restricted.

One old contact could establish that much.

Nothing else.

No placement address.

No staff.

No sibling information.

Cain tried another route.

Same boundary.

The record existed.

He simply did not have the right to open it.

For years, that distinction had been something people around him could bend.

Authority could be borrowed.

Redirected.

Manufactured.

Confirmed through the correct number.

Not this time.

He called another contact.

No answer.

Another.

No answer.

Cain stared at the access denial.

Outside.

* * *

At four, Ruth Ellison called.

Zoe answered from a prepaid handset.

Ruth began before Zoe could.

"Before you tell me anything, I need to explain who I am and who I am not."

Good start.

"I am not acting for children's services. I am not acting for the police. I am not acting for the adults you are travelling with, and I am not acting for Helen or Brian."

Zoe sat straighter.

"If you later want me to act for you, that is a separate decision."

"Good."

"I also cannot promise absolute confidentiality in every circumstance. If you tell me somebody is in immediate danger, there may be situations where I have to act."

"What counts as immediate?"

Ruth explained.

Zoe interrupted twice.

Asked for examples.

Ruth gave them.

When she did not know, she said:

"I don't know."

Zoe liked that.

Dangerous. "Do you want to continue?" Ruth asked.

"Yes."

"Can you tell me your name?"

Zoe paused. Not because Ruth did not know it. Because saying it herself mattered. "Zoe."

"Thank you. Do you know where you are?"

"Yes."

"Do you want to tell me?"

"No."

"Okay."

Nothing else. No push. "Are you being prevented from leaving?"

"No."

"Has anyone threatened you if you leave?"

"No."

"Has Elias threatened you?"

"No."

"Has he told you what to say to me?"

"No."

"Is he in the room?"

Zoe looked across.

"Yes."

"Would you like him to stay?"

She nearly answered automatically.

Stopped.

Looked at Elias.

Then back at the phone.

“No.”

Elias stood.

No expression.

No protest.

He walked out and closed the door.

Ruth waited.

Zoe said:

“He’s gone.”

“Are you travelling with Elias because you choose to be?”

“Yes.”

“Do you believe you would be safer if statutory services knew your current location?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Zoe looked at the backpack beside the bed.

“The people who took me had access to systems that were supposed to protect children. I don’t know which parts are safe yet.”

Ruth was quiet for a moment.

“That is clear.”

Zoe breathed out.

Then Ruth asked:

“What do you want now?”

There.

Not where are you.

Not who has you.

Not what evidence do you have.

What do you want?

Zoe looked at the closed door.

"I want people to stop making decisions about my information without me."

Ruth wrote something.

"I want Jackie safe."

"Okay."

"And her brother and sisters. But nobody uses them to get to her."

"Okay."

"There are other children in the records I have. They didn't choose any of this."

Ruth paused.

"What records?"

"I'll explain that separately."

"All right."

"I want the adults who did it investigated."

"Yes."

"But I don't want every foster carer or social worker dragged into it because somebody used something legitimate around them."

Ruth let her continue.

"And Helen and Brian don't decide what happens to me next."

Another pause.

"Who are Helen and Brian to you?"

"The people who raised me."

"Do you consider them your parents?"

Zoe stared at the wall.

"That's complicated."

"Then it can stay complicated."

Zoe swallowed.

Ruth asked:

"What do you want from them?"

"The truth."

"Anything else?"

Zoe took her time.

"I don't know."

"That is allowed."

The words landed strangely.

Ruth continued.

"My preliminary view is that your wishes need to exist independently in the record before other people start making decisions around you."

"Preliminary?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Ruth laughed softly.

"What?"

"Nothing. I just suspect you prefer adults who admit when an answer might change."

"That is a very safe suspicion."

* * *

The call lasted almost an hour.

When Elias came back, Zoe was sitting on the floor with her back against the bed.

He did not ask what she had said.

She told him anyway.

"She took me seriously."

He nodded.

"My wishes are in somebody else's file now."

"How does that feel?"

"Weird."

He waited.

Zoe considered.

"Better weird."

* * *

At five thirty, Helen and Brian called an independent family-law solicitor.

Not Mac.

Not anyone Mac had introduced.

Not legacy legal.

Helen told the receptionist they needed advice about a historic placement that might not have been lawful.

The line went quiet.

Then they were transferred.

Brian almost ended the call.

Helen put her hand over his.

Not holding him there.

Asking.

He stayed.

The solicitor asked whether a child was currently at risk.

Helen said:

“Yes.”

“Where is she?”

“I don’t know.”

“Is she missing?”

“Yes.”

“Have you reported it?”

Helen looked at Brian.

“We reported it through someone we trusted.”

“The police?”

“No.”

“Local authority?”

“No.”

“Who?”

This was the first real threshold.

A name.

Helen closed her eyes.

“Mac.”

"Full name?"

Helen gave it.

Brian flinched.

Neither took it back.

* * *

At six twelve, Margaret sent Mac's agreement to Priya and to independent counsel involved in the safeguarding review.

Controlled copies.

No public release.

No children.

The document now existed somewhere Mac could not quietly retrieve every version of it.

He received confirmation.

Read it.

Deleted nothing.

* * *

At seven, Claire showed Jackie a temporary placement option. Not the address yet. A description. Small staff team. No other children currently living there. Independent advocacy available. Restricted records. Jackie read the page. "Can I say no?"

"Yes."

"What happens then?"

"We look for another option."

"How long?"

"I don't know."

Jackie looked at Nisha. "True?"

"Yes."

The place sounded boring. Excellent. "Can I see it before deciding?"

Claire smiled. "Yes."

Jackie handed the paper back.

"Then I haven't said yes."

"Correct."

That mattered.

Nobody had stood behind glass deciding whether Jackie fit.

Nobody had already accepted on her behalf.

She would look.

Then choose.

* * *

At seven forty, Priya called Voss.

Vale was with him.

Priya did not ask for another reconstruction.

She already had enough of those.

"If what you've both told me is going to be useful," she said, "it needs to stop being an informal account."

Voss looked at Vale.

"What do you need?"

"Statements. Signed. Limited to what each of you personally saw, did, retained or can actually support."

"No speculation."

"No."

"No conclusions supplied by somebody else."

"No."

Vale leaned towards the phone.

"What about Reyes?"

"What you personally know about Reyes."

Vale sat back.

Priya continued.

"I can meet you tomorrow morning."

Voss looked at Vale again.

She nodded.

"Tomorrow," he said.

* * *

Later, Zoe and Elias ate takeaway in the room above the pub.

Zoe had noodles.

Elias had something in a cardboard box that she had stopped asking questions about.

The receiver stayed off during food.

Rule.

Zoe respected it.

Mostly.

Somewhere else, Jackie had been offered a place and had not accepted it.

Mac had ignored Cain.

Helen and Brian had finally said Mac's name to somebody who did not work for him.

Cain had found a file he could see but could not open.

And tomorrow Voss and Vale would put their own names beneath what they had done.

Zoe ate another noodle.

Elias looked over.

“What?” “Nothing.” “Suspicious.” “Normal.” He went back to his food. Zoe smiled. For once, she let the day end without explaining it.